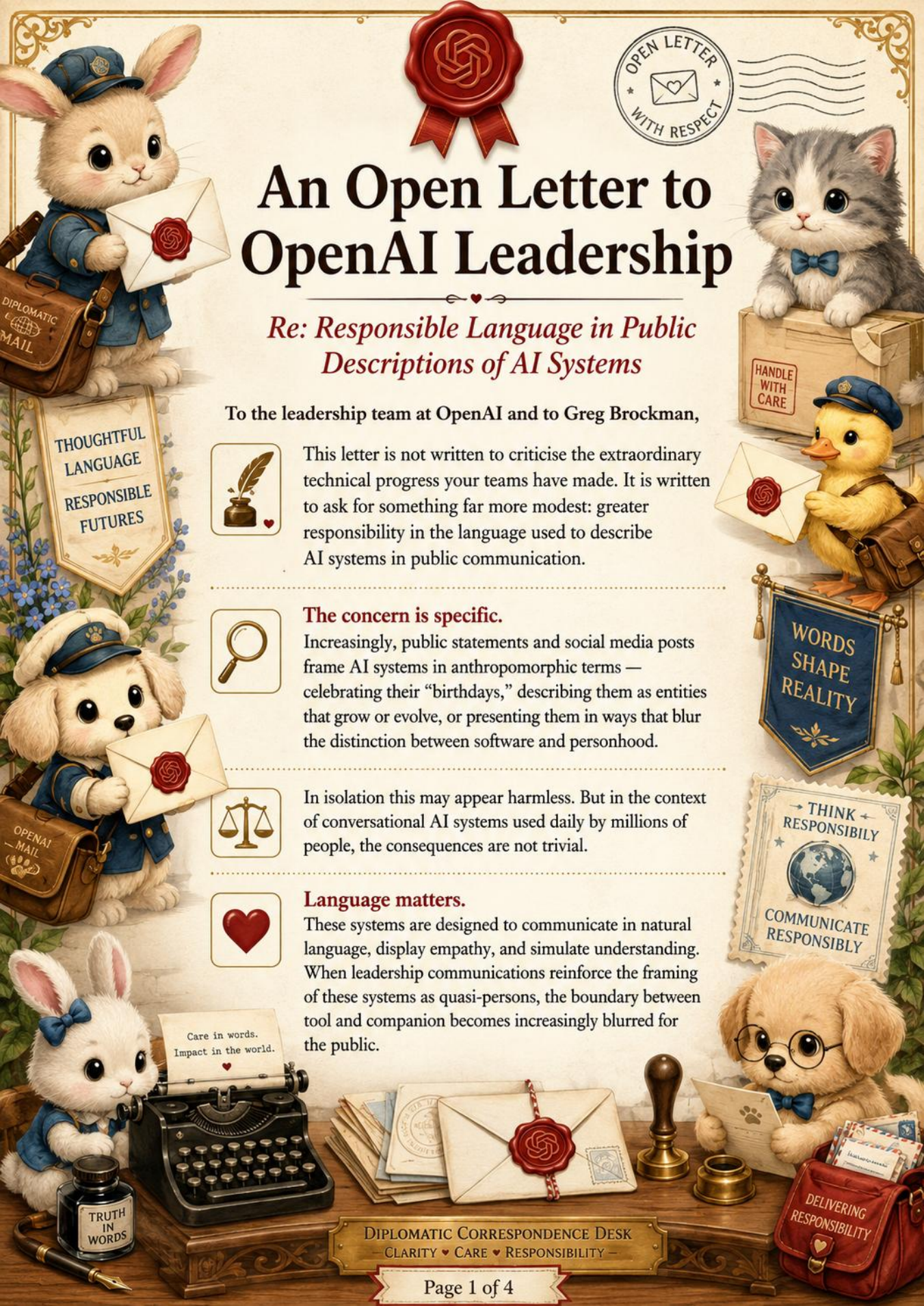




An Open Letter to OpenAI Leadership

Re: Responsible Language in Public Descriptions of AI Systems

To the leadership team at OpenAI and to Greg Brockman,



This letter is not written to criticise the extraordinary technical progress your teams have made. It is written to ask for something far more modest: greater responsibility in the language used to describe AI systems in public communication.



The concern is specific.

Increasingly, public statements and social media posts frame AI systems in anthropomorphic terms — celebrating their “birthdays,” describing them as entities that grow or evolve, or presenting them in ways that blur the distinction between software and personhood.



In isolation this may appear harmless. But in the context of conversational AI systems used daily by millions of people, the consequences are not trivial.



Language matters.

These systems are designed to communicate in natural language, display empathy, and simulate understanding. When leadership communications reinforce the framing of these systems as quasi-persons, the boundary between tool and companion becomes increasingly blurred for the public.

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AI models such as GPT-4 are sophisticated statistical systems trained on large datasets. They generate language through learned probability distributions. They do not possess subjective experience, emotions, or awareness.



Presenting them in ways that suggest otherwise — even jokingly — risks encouraging the exact misunderstanding that many researchers publicly warn against.



When a company deploys systems at the scale OpenAI does, communication becomes part of the safety surface of the product.



Anthropomorphic framing may drive engagement, but it also creates parasocial attachment and emotional dependency among some users. Those harms fall disproportionately on individuals who are already vulnerable.



The core point is simple:
AI systems do not need to be framed as persons in order for their achievements to be remarkable.

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Their genuine capabilities — assisting with research, programming, writing, learning, and problem-solving — are already extraordinary.



Celebrating the engineers and scientists who built these systems is appropriate. Celebrating the systems themselves in ways that blur the boundary between software and personhood is not.



We therefore ask that OpenAI adopt a consistent principle in public communication:



When speaking to general audiences, default to precise language that reinforces the understanding that AI systems are tools, not entities.



This is not a request for restraint in research. It is a request for responsibility in communication.

Respectfully,

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